The India government was sceptical, nevertheless, that Bolshevism was the problem Cox believed it to be. Instead, it emphasised the danger of growing pan-Islamism in the post-war years.[39] Prior to 1918, pan-Islamism had already been simmering steadily beneath the surface of India. Since the late nineteenth century, more and more Muslims had come to the realisation that the expansion of European power was increasingly subjecting Muslims to Christian rule. Indian Muslims started to grow suspicious of Britain, and actions such as the 1911 revocation of the partitioning of Bengal did not help matters.[40] Nevertheless, they had remained loyal to the British crown, and the political reforms sought by the Muslim League had always been consistent with the maintenance of British control.[41] That is, until after the First World War. Although many Muslims fought in the Indian army, there was a growing discomfort among them at the fact that they were in conflict with the Ottoman Empire, the last remaining bastion of Islamic power in the twentieth century.[42] Nationalist feeling also mingled with pan-Islamic sentiment, the one serving to encourage the other.

Kemal Ataturk (president of Turkey, 1923–1938) was particularly adept at utilising the Islamic factor to strengthen nationalism, realising that a national Turkish awakening could be achieved through the use and mobilisation could only be achieved by the use of Islamic symbols.'[43] Only through deft handling of Indian, Persian and Afghan affairs during the war had Britain been able to avoid a mass Muslim uprising in support of Turkey. Muslim agitation had not abated with the armistice, however. Rather, it had gained in strength in the immediate post-war years, in part due to the Allied handling of the Turkish peace process.[44]

While there were some in the Home government who paid little heed to Muslim or nationalist discontent in Asia, the Indian government was absorbed by it in the years after 1918. On 3 December 1918, the India Office drew up a memorandum on 'The Future of Russian Central Asia' in which it noted 'that of [the] 10,000,000 inhabitants of various provinces [of the region], only 500,000 are Russian, the rest are fanatical Muslims'.[45] According to this report then, while Bolshevism might prove some irritation to Britain's interests in the region, the real threat came in the form of Muslim extremism. In the post-war years debate would rage as to whether Britain should fear Bolshevism more than pan-Islamism and nationalism.